FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

For about half a century, the aspiring Indian classes have dreamt of a degree from a US university as the passport to a bright future. Those in hot pursuit of that goal had burgeoned in recent years. In 2023-24, India topped international student charts on US campuses, overtaking China for the first time since 2009. Of the all-time high of over 1.1 million foreign students, Indian students accounted for 331,602, or close to 30 per cent. Now, that dream may be coming to an end, with their life's plans being ambushed just as they were about to take off. The Donald Trump administration is yanking away the welcome mat for incoming international students at US universities. It has paused all new student visa appointments at its embassies worldwide till more stringent norms are put into place. That includes vetting the social media posts of applicants. There are proposals to cap foreign student enrolment at Harvard University at 15 per cent, down from the current 31 per cent. Worse, the Optional Practical Training (OPT) programme, which had enabled 97,556 Indian students in 2023-24 to gain US work experience, may be shut down or severely curtailed. Indian students also make up nearly 50 per cent of those who have had their visas cancelled and face deportation.

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Countless young scholars globally are plunged into a state of anxious limbo; a significant majority are here in India. Nervousness is the predominant sentiment. Most students this magazine reached out to, whether in the US or those who hope to get there, preferred to speak only if anonymity was guaranteed, for fear of adverse consequences on their visa status. The case of a 24-year-old female student typifies the experience. Admitted into a US university for a master's in Computer Science, with specialisation in AI, her visa application was rejected for no apparent reason. She has applied again, and has her fingers tightly crossed. If the process does not pan out favourably for those like her, it would represent a considerable investment of time, money and effort gone waste. University applications cost Rs 10,000-15,000 per institution, while education consultants typically charge Rs 5-6 lakh. Also, many students have already paid tuition fees or booked housing, sums that may not be recoverable if a visa does not materialise. As B.K. Shukla of college application consultancy The Ivy League Edge says, the real blow is the opportunity cost. What's worse, for those crushed thus, direct legal avenues appear severely limited. The US State Department is immune from lawsuits abroad over visa denial.

At the heart of this clampdown is a blend of politics, racial and economic paranoias. Trump's 'America First' vision casts overseas students as job stealers, no different from tariffs taking American jobs. His trade tariffs blitz rolled back global commerce. Now, his attack on universities represents a setback for the one area in which America led the world without challenge. While Chinese scholars may have been the primary target because of the belief that they pilfer high-end technological knowhow, perhaps Indian students are collateral damage.

Mixed in with this is an internal project, what the American conservative right calls "cleansing the system". This entails cutting off vital research funding to universities. Elite institutions like Harvard, which valued liberal arts and open thought, are now cast as adversaries. To the Trumpian mind, they appear as hostile, defiant islands that provoke inherent distrust, hubs of an ideology they despise. This is reflected most acutely in the new component added to visa rules: the intense scrutiny of social media accounts. Cyberspace is the frontline where much of the global ideological battles over hot-button issues like Gaza are being fought. Washington does not want dissent entering its classrooms. But fear is irrational and indiscriminate. Prof. Pablo S. Bose of the University of Vermont says the crackdown has "already had disastrous consequences". His Columbia peer Elora Mukherjee says the policy "seems driven by cruelty, white nationalism, and racism", with visa decisions now vulnerable to prejudice.

Our cover story lays out an exhaustive synopsis of this evolving tragedy, covering all angles with multiple bureau inputs. A companion piece by Aashish Khullar, a Carr-Ryan Center Fellow at Harvard, tells the story from inside the trenches, as it were, as one of the world's premier institutions slips into a "survival state". Our conversations with educators, counsellors and students also reveal slivers of hope. Vibha Kagzi, a Harvard alumna and founder of consultancy Reachivy.com, is not alone in believing the "American dream" is merely being recalibrated, not extinguished. "Historically, policy shifts in international education have corrected themselves," she says. Others are looking at safer (and cheaper) pastures like Germany, which witnessed a 68 per cent increase in uptake between 2022 and 2024. We give you a blow-by-blow rundown of Trump's policy changes, historical trends, the exact things to look out for in the new visa regime, as well as an overview of alternatives.

A word to students: one dream ending is not a permanent nightmare. The world is still your oyster.

(Aroon Purie)